

GAMES, WHICH FROM A LONG WAYS OFF LOOKS LIKE FLIES

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Editor's Note: The production schedule for the last volume of the journal prevented the publication of this essay, which originally was to have been included in the CAD Forum for that year. We are pleased to publish this contribution to the ongoing conversation about gaming. -- BRM

Professor Snider's essay "Gamemaster: It Is You?", which appears in the previous volume of this journal, is less an explanation or vindication of gaming theory than it is a celebration of new developments that have opened up the pursuit of debating to many new individuals who had not been previously exposed to training in debate. I have myself spent the last three years working to find ways to bring public speaking, argument literacy, and other skills associated with debating to populations who needed a course in these skills. I am, therefore, sympathetic to Professor Snider's cause of "debate evangelism."

However, I am not convinced that the characterization of debate as "game" has much, if anything, to do with the larger objectives he seems to endorse. In fact, it may be that relying on the "gaming paradigm" for understanding and teaching debate turns out to be a wrong or dangerous approach. In fact, it may be impossible to make this kind of evaluation based on the information given in any of Snider's publications on the subject of the debate-as-game concept.

It seems like one could endorse all of Professor Snider's conclusions about debate and the value of training in debate, while still not endorsing his concepts of "gaming." In fact, I would suggest that his conclusions should be worded even more strongly. There is a pressing need in our society for training in argument literacy and oral communication. The overwhelming majority of students graduate from high school unable to identify or

discriminate between good reasoning and bad reasoning. Most of these students have never been taught how to make an argument or how to identify persuasive techniques they might face in their own lives. These students are disabled in their lives by this lack of training. They are left to the devices of non-altruistic political parties, corporations, and media outlets that want little else except to gain the passive, consuming consent of the viewing public. In some parts of America, 40% or more of students do not even graduate from high school – these students receive even less training.

This lack of training does a grave disservice to our students. If they do not have the necessary oral communication and critical thinking skills to survive and prosper in society, how will they ever rise above the level of mere consuming animal? How will they organize themselves to create better working and living conditions for their families and communities? How will they ever form political opinions other than those that are given to them by whoever has the most money to buy paper for leaflets, commercial airtime, or network ownership?

On the other hand, perhaps we should not teach debate at all. When we teach debating, we teach demagoguery – we show our students how to form the most persuasive arguments for the audience at hand, how to shape the facts to suit their own conclusion, and how to convince individuals to act against their own self-interest. We teach students how to form political opinions for others, to strategize effectively to buy that paper, commercial airtime, or network ownership. Students who debate often lack critical thinking skills, as they grow up without serious exposure to art, music, dance, and other pursuits that have little (seemingly, at least) to do with their immediate success in debates. These students often lack vision because their vision has been restricted to the realm of the printed, the politically possible, the sound bite, or that which is supported by block quotes. Others realize that their powers of persuasion mean there is little limit to their potential earning power and certainly no reason to follow any easily rationalized system of ethical or moral behavior, and so they simply cast those aside. To assume that debate is the path to a more

progressive or moral society is to make some very dangerous assumptions about humanity and its motivations and desires.

What does any of this have to do with gaming? Either everything or nothing, but only because these (potentially very) mixed results have to do with debate, and debate is defined as a game. If we want to debate about debating, we should go ahead and do it. Why attach the gaming paradigm as a descriptor? Snider fails to provide a convincing warrant for using the gaming paradigm to understand the issues involved in debate and debate promotion. His approach seems akin to learning how to drive a car while you learn to boil an egg – the two tasks should perhaps be separate, as they have nothing to do with each other.

There is really no such thing as the gaming paradigm – that the characterization of debate as a game is just a definitional move that lacks critical leverage. One of the most interesting aspects of the “gaming” paradigm is that, like Oakland, there may be no *there* there. Which is to say that Professor Snider makes no attempt to define a game or the process of gaming other than by what it is not (and even then, not so much).

Always Already Game

Professor Snider has used his considerable argumentative talents to create an admirably ergonomic tautology, all of which basically boils down to this simple, non-reversible, definition: debate is a game. One could argue against this definitional move, but such argument would undermine itself and be a largely pointless exercise, as the arguee (in this case Professor Snider) would just comment that you were now proving his point by engaging in the game of debate. This “discussion” might mirror the “debates” you can have with your local conspiracy theorist:

Conspiracy theorist: You know, the government’s controlling your mind.

You: No they’re not.

Conspiracy theorist: That’s just what they want you to think.

And so on. This conversation may actually characterize most of Snider’s writing on the gaming paradigm. Now, debate by definition may be the easiest and most effective way to

stymie dissent (or, interestingly, debate – more on this problem later), but it does not therefore follow that this argumentative strategy is the most useful or descriptive tool we have at our disposal.

One problem I encountered when trying to formulate a response to Professor Snider's article "Gamemaster: It Is You?" was the problem of gaining a critical foothold. If one is to respond to the proposition that debate is a game, understood as the most simplistic expression of the "gaming" paradigm, one must first understand what it is that "gaming" is. While Professor Snider does not define gaming *per se*, he does offer some indirect explanations of what gaming is and is not, summarized here in a handy chart:

Gaming is:	Gaming is not:
"a paradigm for academic debate"	A strategic tool
an explanatory paradigm	A construct forced onto the actual procedures of debating
Invisible	
a theoretical approach	
outside (dances of argument take place "inside the game")	
Afoot	

Gaming is the invisible/outside. It is afoot, but is not a strategic tool. It is an explanatory paradigm that is not a construct. It is also (one assumes) not a pipe. Gaming, or perhaps more properly *the game*, is the center elsewhere. Professor Snider describes the gaming paradigm as a *weltanschauung*, or world view. Given the rather circumspect definitions we have been given, gaming might better be described as the *wunderursprung*, or miraculous origin.

But the origin is not so miraculous. There is, really, only one definitional operation underway here, and that is the defining of debate as game. By the way, this is not actually a

definition, if what we mean by *defining a word* is finding meaning by a process of interpretation. Rather, this is word-substitution, or re-naming. In any case, as I have remarked earlier, this is a tautology masquerading as a proof. If debate *is* in its very “essence,” as Professor Snider argues, a game, then there is really no debate to be had on the matter. Interestingly, his theoretical operation functions to prohibit or render ineffective any criticism of the description of debate as a game, because, after all, debate *is* a game: “debate was *already* a game before my articles appeared.” Debate is engaging, according to Snider, because it is a “critical discourse game.” not a “formalized and communicative process.”

In Snider’s words, “If something is everywhere, it is easier for us all of a sudden to find it nowhere.” This is an apt description of the gaming paradigm – it is said to be everywhere, and thus is found nowhere. It is “invisible,” and “outside.” One can only wonder how Snider happened upon it in the first place. This is a neat trick, to be sure, but hardly the kind of jaw-dropping sleight of hand that normally distinguishes serious theory. In fact, Snider may be engaging in that most feared of debate mistakes – the double turn. By arguing from definition and thereby assuming what he purports to prove, he is short-circuiting debate – precisely what he says is good.

Further, an endorsement of the debate-as-game concept may in fact contradict Snider’s arguments for the expansion and redefinition of debate. If debate is, by definition, a game, and games are good, then Snider must accept the present state of debate, no matter how dysfunctional. The definitional move of debate-as-game has no critical purchase for arguments which seek to promote, change, or revolutionize debate, as it is really a *de facto* endorsement of the present state of things, whatever state that might be. Now, Snider may deny this by pointing out that he *does* in fact encourage active rethinking and reinvention of academic and other kinds of debating. This only proves my point, however: gaming, as a concept, is irrelevant to debates over the state of debate. One can, for example, agree that there should be more debate while disagreeing with the debate-as-game concept. In a funny way, this is also Snider’s point – gaming is neither here nor there; it is all things solid, melting into air. Hardly a stable grounds for critical inquiry.

In a way, it might be too bad that Snider has now written about gaming. Now that his thoughts about the debate-as-game concept have been set sown and published, gaming is no longer outside or invisible. So if he's right about what the "gaming paradigm" is, then he may be responsible for destroying gaming by writing about it. Perhaps, after all, he means all of this ironically.

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